RETAIL ANALYTICS CASE STUDY

Global Superstore Sales & Profitability Analysis

A four-year performance review of a global retail operation — uncovering the hidden cost of discounting

Dataset	**Global Superstore · 51,290 transactions**
Period	**FY2011 – FY2014 (48 months)**
Scope	**147 countries · 7 markets · 3 segments**
Tools	**Excel · Power Pivot · DAX Measures · Interactive Dashboard**
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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Business at a Glance

Global Superstore is a multinational retailer selling furniture, office supplies, and technology products across 147 countries. Between 2011 and 2014, the business generated **$12.64M in sales** and **$1.47M in net profit** — an overall margin of 11.6%. Sales grew 90% over the four-year period, reflecting healthy top-line expansion.

However, a deeper analysis reveals a critical issue hidden beneath the growth: **an aggressive discounting strategy is silently destroying profitability**. While the business appears healthy on the surface, orders with discounts above 20% collectively erased $814K in profit — money that went straight to the bottom line's detriment.

Key Metrics

$12.64M	$1.47M	11.6%	25,035	1,590	147
TOTAL SALES	NET PROFIT	PROFIT MARGIN	ORDERS	CUSTOMERS	COUNTRIES

The Central Finding

> *"Every discount tier above 20% operated at a loss. The deeper the discount, the deeper the loss — turning revenue growth into margin erosion."*

This report walks through the market performance, category mix, customer segments, and — most importantly — the discount-profit relationship that demands immediate management attention. Four strategic recommendations are provided, each with quantified impact.

SECTION 01

Market & Category Performance

Sales & Profit by Market

APAC and EU are the twin engines of the business, together contributing 52% of global sales. But the most striking insight is **Canada**: despite the smallest sales volume ($67K), it delivers the highest profit margin at 27% — more than double the company average. This suggests an underexploited high-margin market worth strategic investment.

Market	Sales	Profit	Margin
APAC	$3.59M	$436K	12%
EU	$2.94M	$373K	13%
US	$2.30M	$286K	12%
LATAM	$2.16M	$222K	10%
EMEA	$0.81M	$44K	5%
Africa	$0.78M	$89K	11%
Canada	$0.07M	$18K	27%

EMEA shows the weakest margin (5%) — a flag for pricing or cost review. Canada (27%) is the hidden margin champion.

Category Mix

Revenue is well-diversified across three categories — Technology (37.5%), Furniture (32.5%), and Office Supplies (30.0%). This balance reduces dependency risk. However, category-level sales mask sub-category problems: within Furniture, the **Tables sub-category lost $64K**, making it the single worst-performing product line in the portfolio.

Most vs. Least Profitable Sub-Categories

Sub-Category	Profit	Status
Copiers	$258.6K	Top performer
Phones	$216.7K	Top performer
Bookcases	$161.9K	Strong
Fasteners	$11.5K	Marginal
Tables	-$64.1K	Loss-making

SECTION 02

The Discount Problem

This is the most important finding of the entire analysis. When profit is broken down by discount band, a clear and alarming pattern emerges: **discounting beyond 20% does not just reduce profit — it produces outright losses.**

Discount Band	Profit / (Loss)	Verdict
No Discount	+$1,770,695	Highly profitable
Low (1–20%)	+$511,444	Profitable
Medium (21–40%)	-$187,271	Loss
High (40%+)	-$627,411	Severe loss

Combined loss $814,682

The Medium and High discount bands together destroyed $814K in profit. Had these orders been sold at a maximum 20% discount, company profit could have been materially higher. The discount policy is the single largest controllable drain on profitability.

Why This Matters

No-discount and low-discount orders generated $2.28M in combined profit. The two high-discount bands gave back $814K of it — meaning roughly **36% of the profit earned from disciplined pricing was surrendered through over-discounting.** This is not a volume problem; it is a pricing-discipline problem, and it is entirely within management's control to fix.

Customer Segments

The Consumer segment drives the majority of profit ($749K), followed by Corporate ($441K) and Home Office ($277K). Consumer is the priority segment for retention and targeted marketing, while the discount discipline recommended below applies across all three.

SECTION 03

Strategic Recommendations

1

Institute a 20% discount ceiling

Cap standard discounts at 20%. Any discount beyond this threshold must route through manager approval with a documented business justification. This directly targets the $814K loss zone.

Expected impact: Recover a significant share of the $814K currently lost to over-discounting.

2

Fix or exit the Tables sub-category

Tables lost $64K over the period — the only loss-making sub-category. Conduct a cost-and-pricing review; if it cannot reach breakeven, consider discontinuation or supplier renegotiation.

Expected impact: Eliminate a recurring $64K annual drag on Furniture profitability.

3

Invest in the Canada & high-margin markets

Canada delivers a 27% margin — more than double the company average — on minimal volume. Increase marketing and inventory allocation to replicate this margin profile in comparable markets.

Expected impact: Scale a proven 27%-margin model into a larger revenue base.

4

Prioritise the Consumer segment

Consumer generates 51% of total profit. Direct retention programmes, loyalty incentives, and targeted campaigns here — while holding the discount discipline from Recommendation 1.

Expected impact: Protect and grow the single largest profit contributor.

SECTION 04

Methodology & Conclusion

Analytical Approach

The raw dataset of 51,290 transactions was cleaned and enriched in Excel with calculated fields for Year, Month-Year, Profit Margin, Discount Band, and Shipping Days. Six pivot analyses were built covering market, category, segment, discount, sub-category, and time trends.

Key metrics — including distinct order and customer counts and profit margin — were calculated using **DAX measures within Excel's Power Pivot data model**, ensuring the interactive dashboard recalculates correctly when filtered by year, market, or segment. This mirrors production-grade BI practice rather than static reporting.

Techniques Applied

- Data cleaning & feature engineering (5 calculated columns)
- Distinct counts via DAX (DISTINCTCOUNT) for accurate order/customer totals
- Profit Margin measure: DIVIDE(SUM(Profit), SUM(Sales))
- Interactive slicers (Year / Market / Segment) connected to all visuals
- Diverging column chart to expose profit-vs-loss discount bands

Conclusion

Global Superstore is a growing business with a hidden margin problem. The 90% sales growth is real and encouraging — but it has masked an $814K profit leak caused by undisciplined discounting. The good news: this is a controllable problem. Implementing a 20% discount ceiling, fixing the Tables line, scaling the Canada margin model, and doubling down on the Consumer segment together form a clear, quantified roadmap to convert top-line growth into sustainable, higher-margin profit.

Global Superstore Analysis · Prepared by Ranjan Sah · Excel · Power Pivot · DAX · 2026